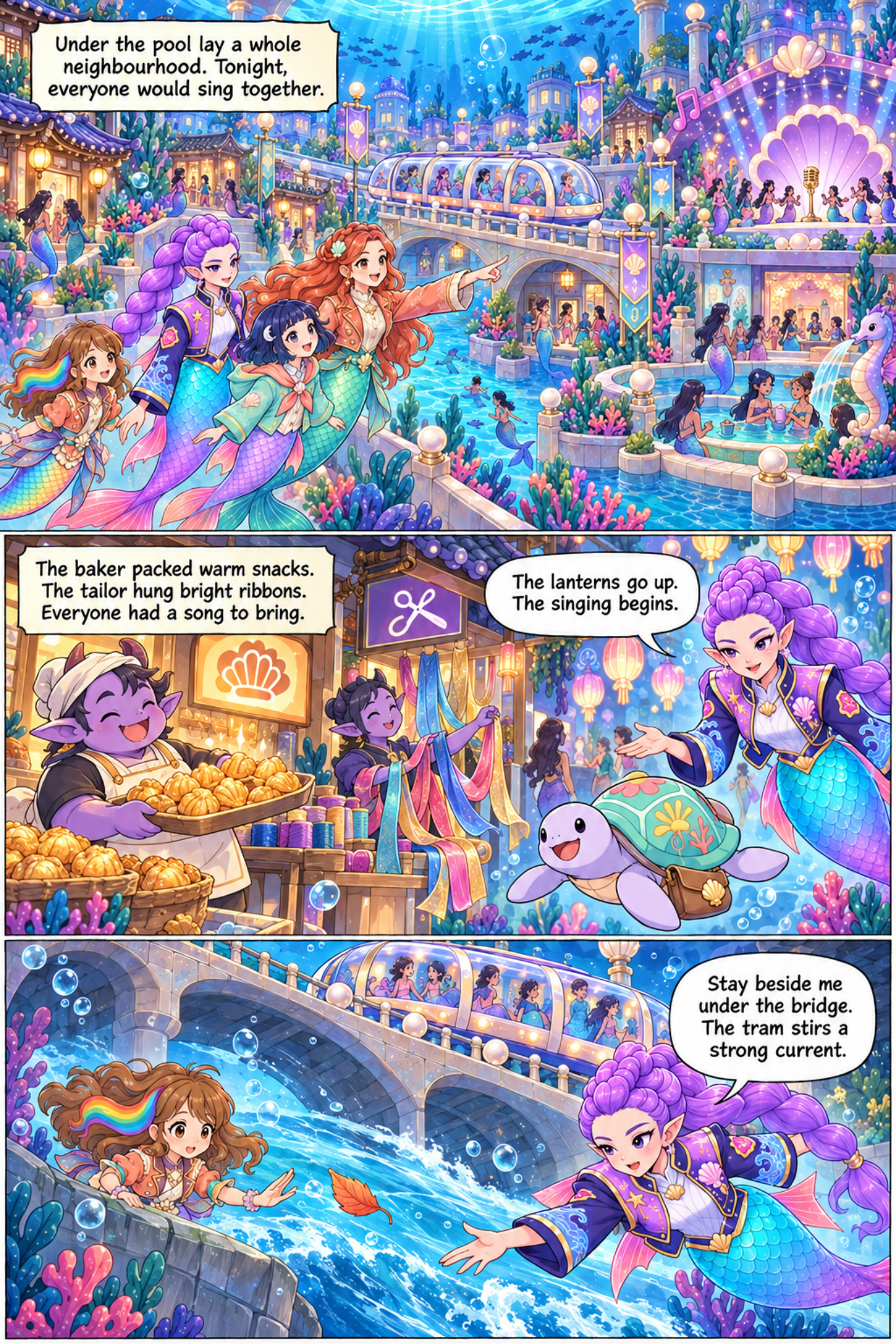
Mermaid Roshan:
Here I Am!
An adventure beneath Rumi's pool

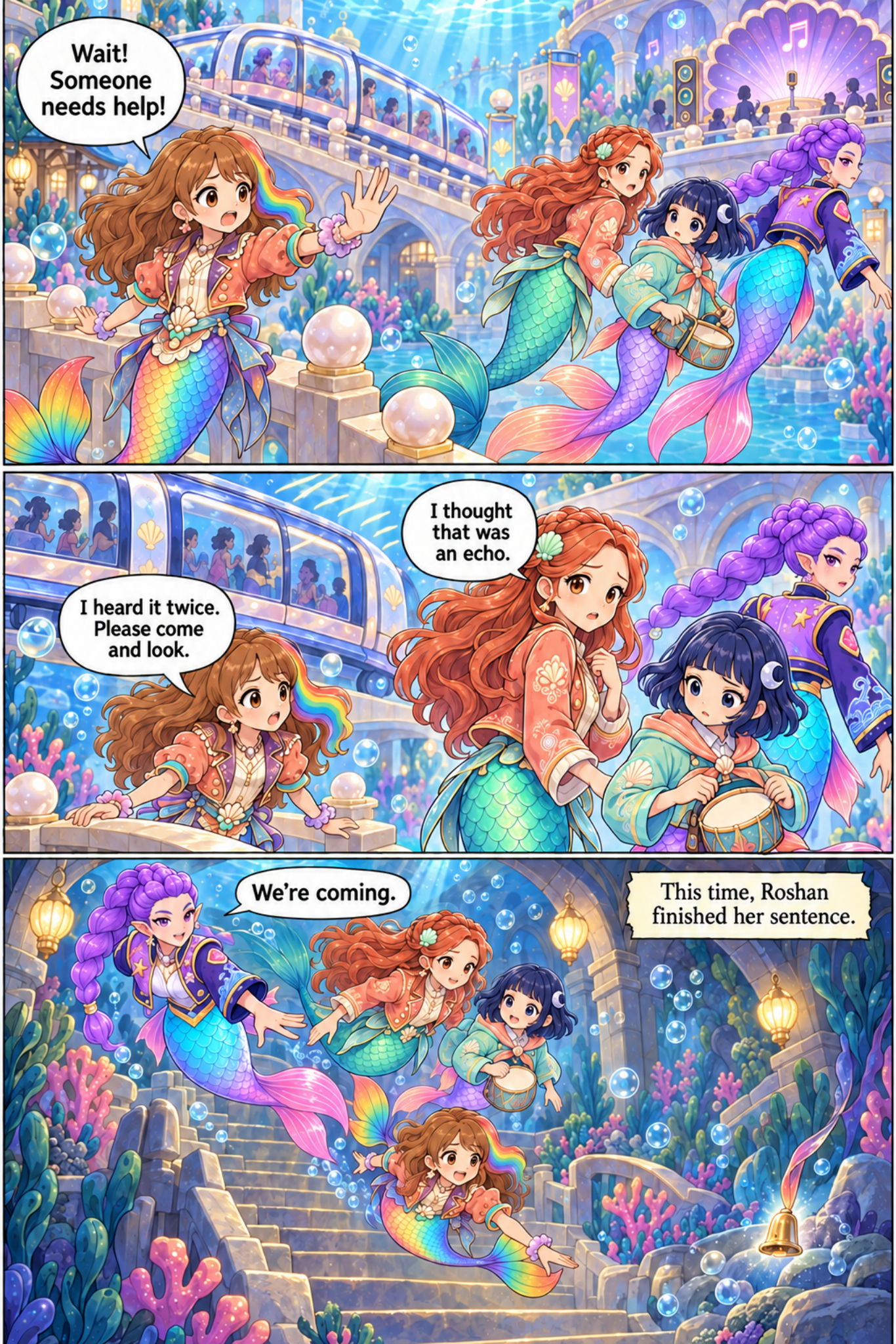
The castle candle was still missing. But tonight, a song was waiting beneath Rumi's pool.
I want to sing the first line. All by myself.
Then let's make that your turn.
What if my voice wobbles?
It can wobble. It's still yours. I'll be beside you, if you want.


Under the pool lay a whole neighbourhood. Tonight, everyone would sing together.
The baker packed warm snacks. The tailor hung bright ribbons. Everyone had a song to bring.
The lanterns go up. The singing begins.
Stay beside me under the bridge. The tram stirs a strong current.

Song Night! Bring your own voice! One last invitation for the bathhouse. Then I get a turn too!
Our entrance will be HUGE!
That fan is hanging over my delivery path.
We'll move it later. Come and clap!
But I need to get through now.

Hana dances.
Nari keeps the beat.
Tonight, Roshan wants...
A giant finish!
And a booming beginning!
I wanted...
Rumi first, then all of us!

Could I sing the...
She had practised her three words all morning. She wanted them to be heard.
BOOM!
The end of her sentence disappeared.
Help!
That wasn't part of the song.


Wait! Someone needs help!
I heard it twice. Please come and look.
I thought that was an echo.
We're coming.
This time, Roshan finished her sentence.

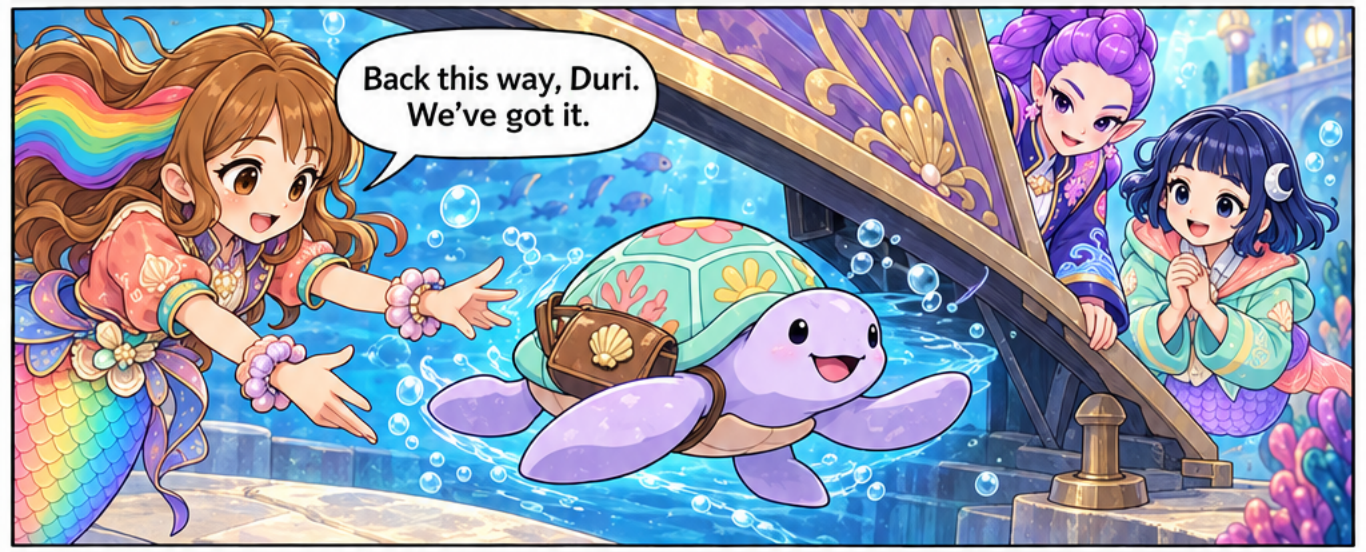
Down here!
We'll go one step at a time.
The fan slipped. My bag is caught, and I can't back out.
I can pull it up!
Wait. That tugs my bag!

Stop!
Hana. Stop pulling. Duri asked us to wait.
I'm stopping. Tell us what you need.
Loosen my bag first. Please.

Push the fan back a little. That will loosen the loop.
I'll hold this edge. Hana, keep it steady.
Loose... and off!

Another tram! Hold on!
WHOOSH! The fan pushed back.
Rumi, I need help at this end!
Coming beside you.

Ready... now!


Back this way, Duri. We've got it.

Four flippers wriggled. One turtle was free!

I told those imps the path was blocked. They just kept talking.
My voice shook when I shouted.
I'm glad you told me to stop. I thought being strong would help. I should have asked first.
Can we rest before we go to the show?
Yes. The bathhouse is right here.

In the warm bathhouse, Roshan found another sentence.
I wanted a turn in the song. You all kept talking.
We did. I promised you a turn, then forgot to make room. I'm sorry.
I chose the song before you could choose.
And my drum was louder than you.

Can we sit in the cooler pool?
Of course.
Not on my head, please.
Would you like a towel?
All right. I'll put it beside you instead.
Then I'll wear enough for two! I am the queen of rabbits!

What would you like your first line to be?
Here I am!
Here you are!
Can we try it again at supper?
As many times as you like. We'll each have a turn.

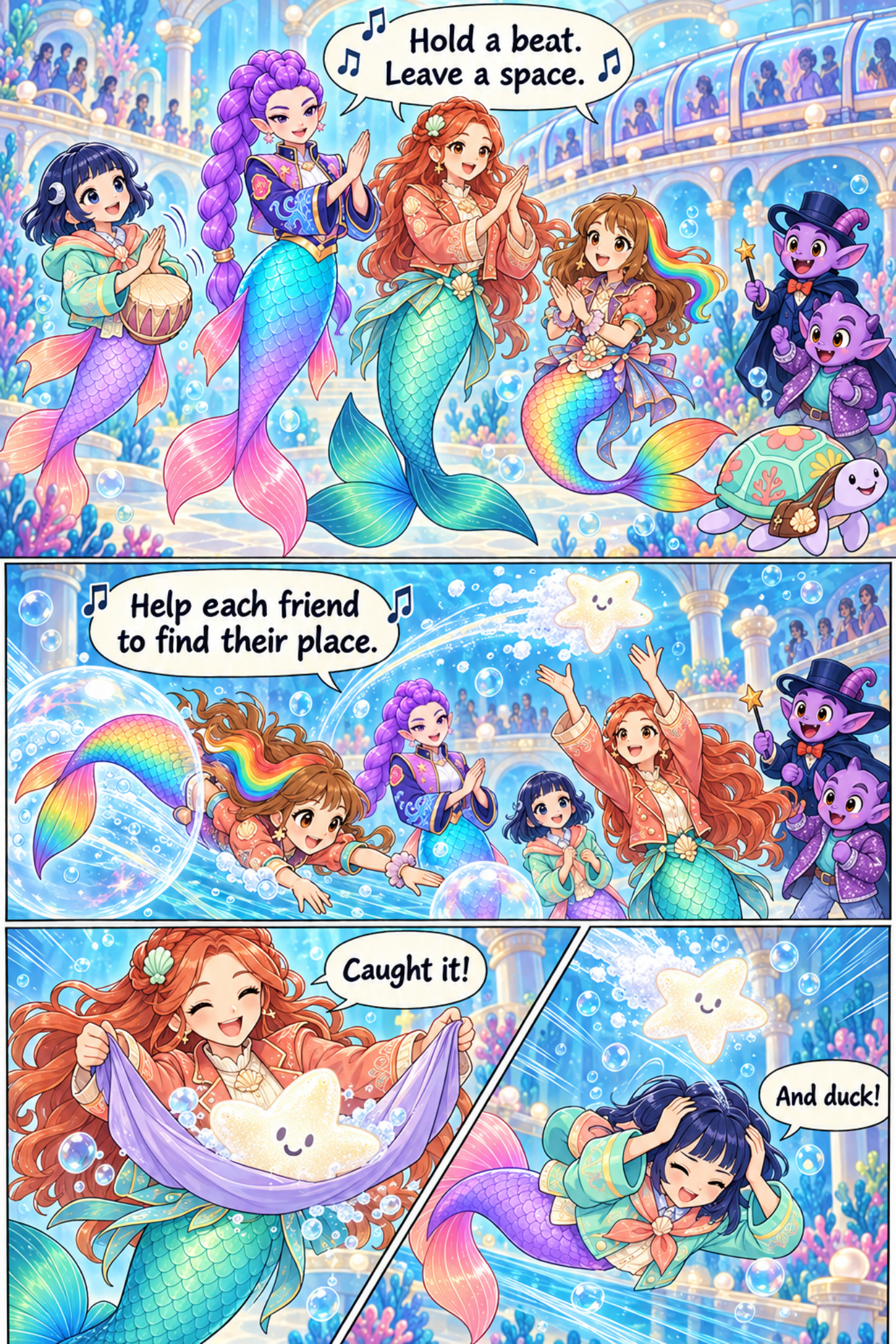
Supper filled a table almost as long as the couch.
A fruit mountain! I'll start at the bottom.
Can I start our song now?
We're listening.
♪ Here I... ♫

SHOWTIME!
Your fan trapped Duri. You need to hear him.
He's right here. Let him tell you.
Later, little voice. Tonight, WE sing. You clap!

I am speaking.
Please listen.
This is everyone's song.
My friends have
something to sing.
And I do too.
If we stop,
they might
forget us!
Roshan has
a turn too.
We can all fit
in one song.

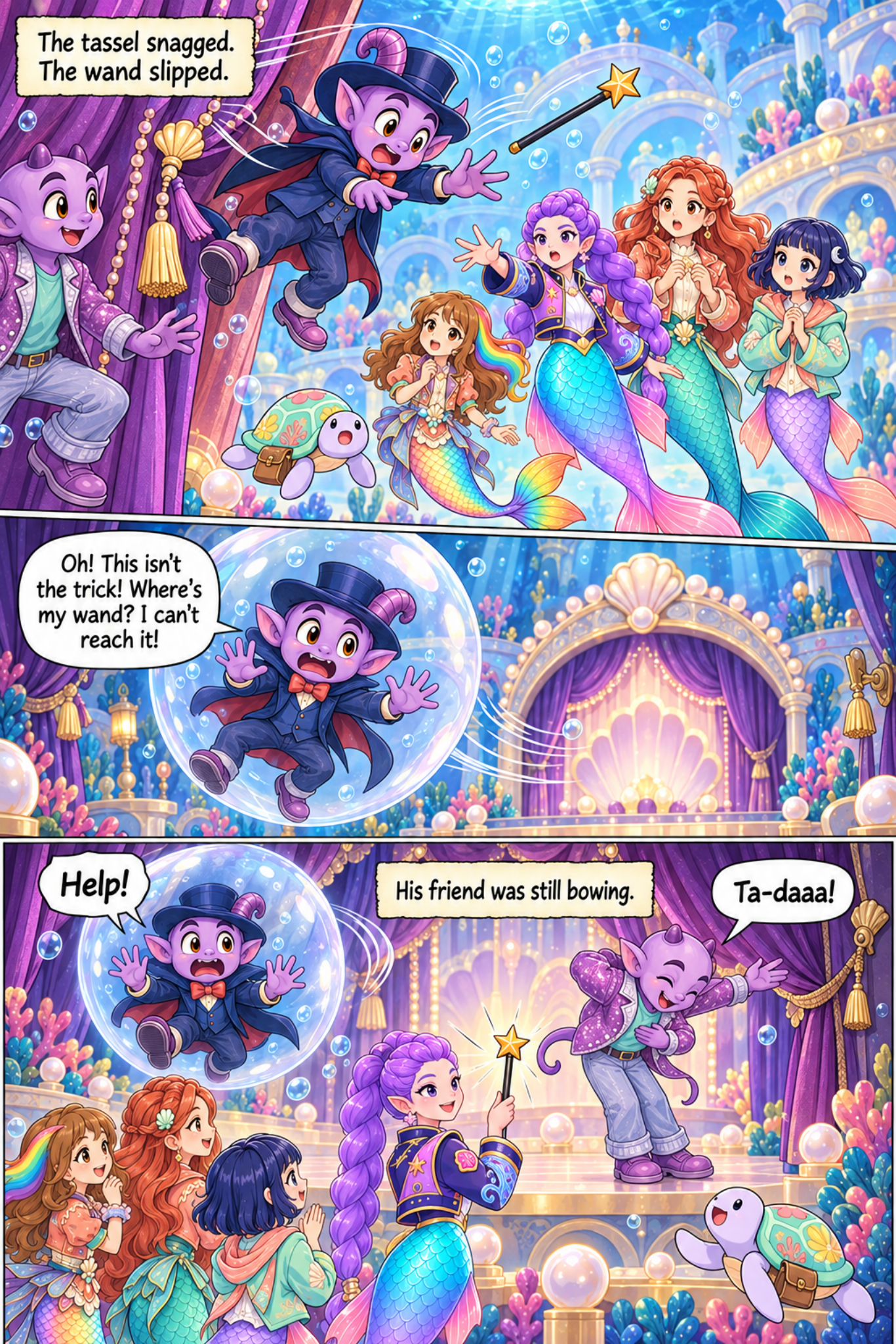
Then watch our BIGGEST trick!
With a tap of his wand, he popped a stray bubble.
Bubbles bulged. Foam stars flew. Nobody could reach the microphone.
I need you beside me. Let's keep a way through.

This way, everyone.
I'll keep the aisle open.
I'll catch the stars.
I'll give us
a swimming beat.
Last delivery!
Now I can help.
I'll go through the gaps.
Duri, ring if the path closes.


Hold a beat.
Leave a space.
Help each friend
to find their place.
Caught it!
And duck!

You're missing our grand finish!
DING!
Pause! I need a different way.
Give us a turn. We'll watch yours too.
The current goes under. Rumi, come with me.

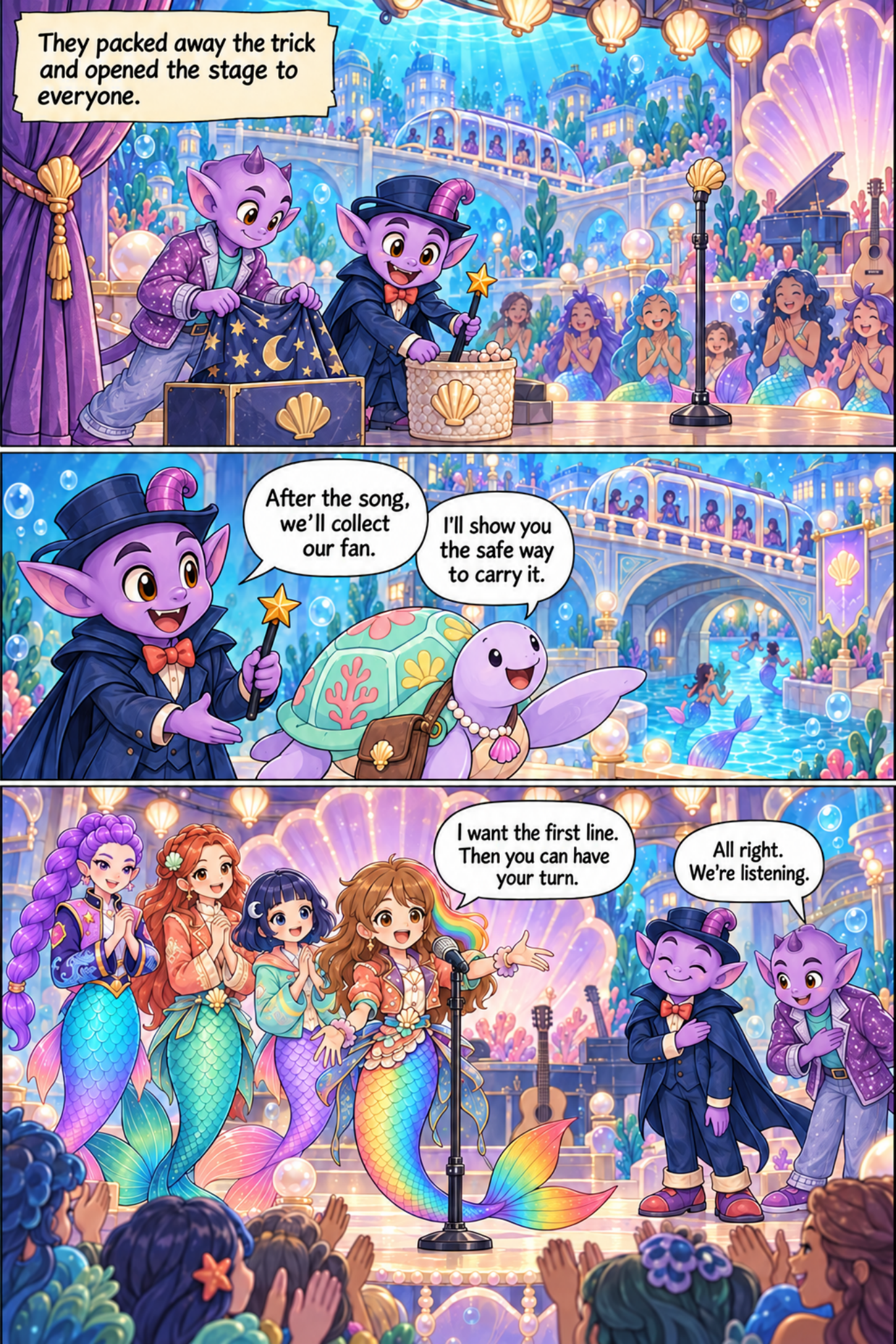
Under the bubbles. Around the curtain. Together!
Stars in the basket!
Space on the stage!
Nobody can miss THIS!


The tassel snagged.
The wand slipped.
Oh! This isn't the trick! Where's my wand? I can't reach it!
Help!
His friend was still bowing.
Ta-daaa!

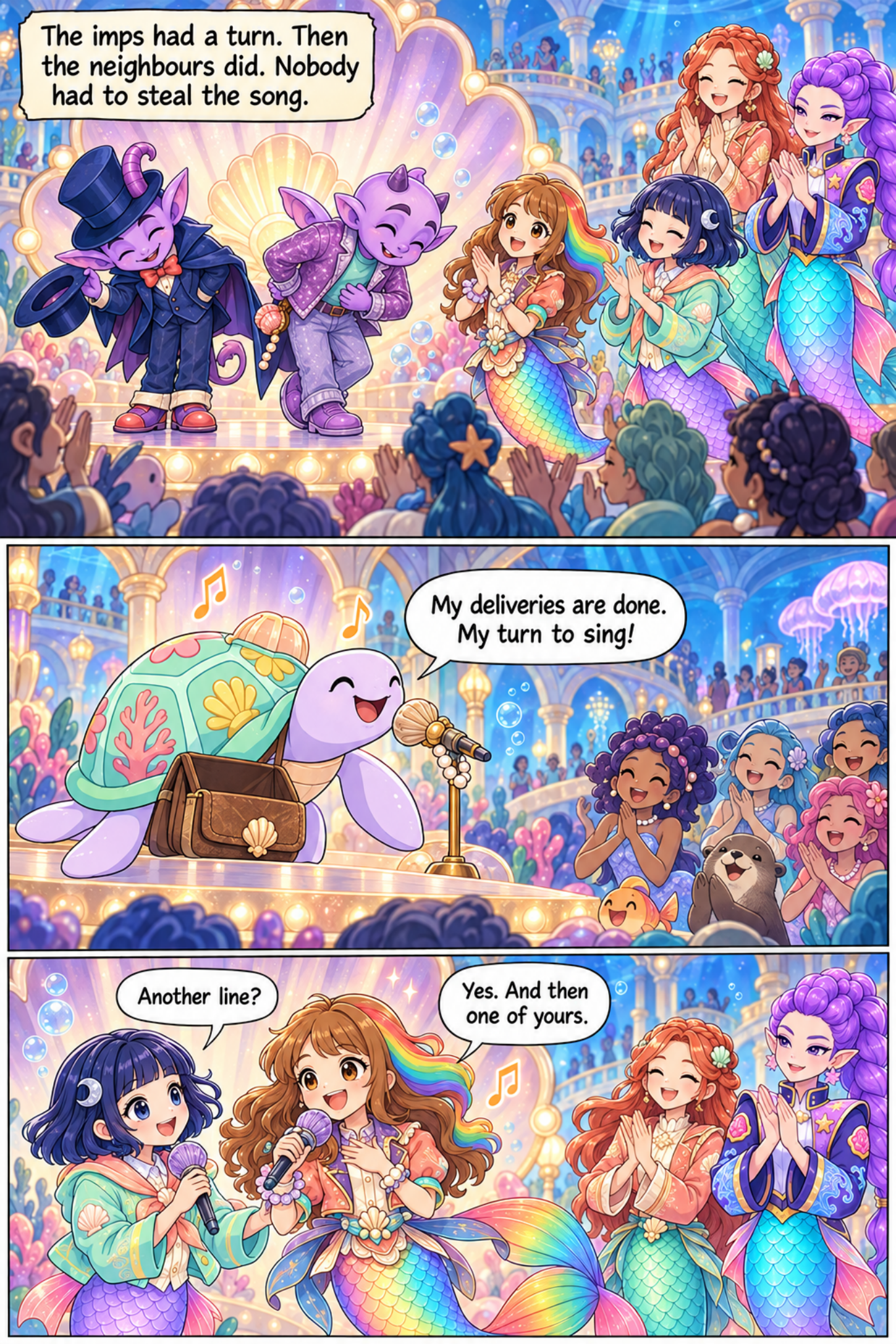
He's waving.
He needs help!
Stop the show!
Listen to him!
This time, nobody
told her to wait.
I can't get out.
We hear you.
We're here.
We won't leave you.

Catch the bubble in the cloth!
Tie back the curtain!
What can I do?
Ready below?
Ready!
POP!
Oof. Thank you.

I called and called. Nobody heard me.
That was how I felt under the bridge.
And when you talked over me.
I'm sorry. We should have listened.
I'm sorry I talked over you. I was afraid nobody would clap.
I was afraid too. I still wanted a turn.


They packed away the trick and opened the stage to everyone.
After the song, we'll collect our fan.
I'll show you the safe way to carry it.
I want the first line. Then you can have your turn.
All right. We're listening.

Her voice wobbled a little.
She sang anyway.
Here I am!
Here you are!
Near or far, big or small,
we make room for us all!


The imps had a turn. Then the neighbours did. Nobody had to steal the song.
My deliveries are done. My turn to sing!
Another line?
Yes. And then one of yours.

They swam back up through Rumi's pool. The rainbow was still turning.
What shall we do tomorrow?
I have an idea. Can I tell you?
I'm listening.
Roshan didn't wait for her voice to be perfect. She began.